

Chapter X: Seasons and Political Turmoil

Much like Chapter V, this is an exceedingly brief chapter—a personal, casual daily essay. It bears no direct relation to the overarching theme of this record, and readers are free to skip it entirely.

As winter approached in late 2022, resistance movements against pandemic control measures erupted across numerous Chinese cities. This was one of the direct catalysts for the abrupt termination of the "Great Anti-Pandemic Enterprise" (抗疫大业) at the end of that year.

Profoundly moved by this, I realized that political upheavals throughout human history share an intimate correlation with the seasons. Consequently, I penned this essay in late August 2023.

Although my spare time is insufficient to conduct a rigorous statistical analysis of all major political events—rebellions, uprisings, and coups that have shaken or subverted regimes throughout human history—and I can only enumerate historical events with which I am relatively familiar, I firmly believe that if someone were to subject this issue to scientific data analysis, this conclusion would be even more comprehensively substantiated.

It is self-evident that, particularly since the advent of the modern era, political upheavals exerting profound impacts on the course of human history have become highly concentrated within the three or four months of winter. For those regions yearning for a radical social transformation, "**General Winter**" (冬将军) stands as the most reliable and formidable ally for the vanguard riding the tides of the era.

Previously, while studying the history of the French Revolution, the name of the historical event the "**Thermidorian Reaction**" (热月政变) left a remarkably deep impression on me. This coup occurred during the month of Thermidor in the French Republican Calendar.

Interestingly, from a historical perspective, the sweltering summer is indeed a peak period for political turbulence. This is simply because the vast majority of human history to date has been the history of agricultural civilizations (*and since the dawn of recorded history, the temperate zones have been the mainstream of human civilization*). Spring is primarily dedicated to sowing, and autumn to harvesting, while the bitter cold of winter makes troop movements exceedingly difficult.

For regimes situated in temperate zones, what could possibly be a more opportune time to wage war than summer? And war, undeniably, is the human activity that inflicts the most devastating destruction upon social wealth, thereby perfectly cultivating the conditions for various coups, rebellions, and uprisings.

One can effortlessly enumerate a myriad of famous or influential major political events of this nature that transpired during the summer:

- **Jacquerie** (扎克雷起义), May-June 1358, Valois Dynasty, France.
- **Peasants' Revolt / Wat Tyler's Rebellion** (瓦特·泰勒起义), June 1381, House of Plantagenet, England.
- **Jack Cade's Rebellion** (凯德起义), June-July 1450, House of Lancaster, England.
- **Silesian Weavers' Uprising** (西里西亚纺织工人起义), June 4, 1844, Kingdom of Prussia.
- **Magna Carta** (《大宪章》), June 15, 1215, House of Plantagenet, England.

- **Honnō-ji Incident** (本能寺之变), June 21, 1582, Azuchi-Momoyama period, Japan.
- **Kakitsu Rebellion** (嘉吉之乱), June 24, 1441, Muromachi Shogunate, Japan.
- **Catherine the Great's Coup** (叶卡捷琳娜二世夺权), June 28, 1762, Russian Empire.
- **Assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand / Sarajevo Incident** (萨拉热窝事件), June 28, 1914, Austro-Hungarian Empire.
- **Poznań Protests** (波兹南事件), June 28, 1956, Polish People's Republic.
- **Night of the Long Knives** (长刀之夜), June 30, 1934, Nazi Germany.
- **Isshi Incident** (乙巳之变), June 645, Asuka period, Japan.
- **Xuanwu Gate Incident** (玄武门之变), July 2, 626, Tang Dynasty.
- **Storming of the Bastille / French Revolution** (大革命), July 14, 1789, Bourbon Dynasty, France.
- **Franco's Coup / Start of Spanish Civil War** (弗朗哥起事), July 17, 1936, Second Spanish Republic.
- **20 July Plot / Operation Valkyrie** (刺杀希特勒), July 20, 1944, Nazi Germany.
- **Tanglong Coup** (唐隆政变), July 21, 710, Tang Dynasty.
- **Egyptian Revolution of 1952** (埃及七月革命), July 23, 1952, Kingdom of Egypt.
- **Thermidorian Reaction** (热月政变), July 27, 1794, French First Republic.
- **July Revolution** (七月革命), Late July 1830, Bourbon Restoration, France.
- **First Defenestration of Prague** (第一次掷出窗外事件), July 30, 1419, Kingdom of Bohemia.
- **Jintian Uprising / Taiping Rebellion** (金田起义), July 1850, Qing Dynasty.
- **Nanchang Uprising** (南昌起义), August 1, 1927, Republic of China.
- **Jingnan Campaign** (靖难之役), August 6, 1399, Ming Dynasty.
- **1991 Soviet Coup d'État Attempt / August Coup** (八一九事件), August 19, 1991, Soviet Union.
- **Outbreak of the English Civil War** (英国内战爆发), August 22, 1642, House of Stuart, England.
- **St. Bartholomew's Day Massacre** (圣巴托洛缪大屠杀), August 24, 1572, Valois Dynasty, France.
- **Hou Jing's Rebellion / Disaster of Taiqing** (太清之难), August 548, Liang Dynasty.
- **Peter the Great's Seizure of Power** (彼得一世夺权), August 1689, Tsardom of Russia.
- **Rice Riots** (米骚动), August 1918, Empire of Japan.
- **Kannō Disturbance** (观应扰乱), Summer of 1349, Muromachi Shogunate.

- **1978 Iranian Protests (1978 年示威)**, Summer of 1978, Pahlavi Dynasty.
- **Disaster of Baima Station (白马驿之祸)**, Summer of 905, Tang Dynasty.
- **Wang Geon's Coup (王建举事)**, Summer of 918, Later Three Kingdoms of Korea.
- **Revolt of the Ciompi (梳毛工起义)**, Summer of 1378, Republic of Florence.

It is glaringly obvious that many of the aforementioned events were closely intertwined with war. Had Toyotomi Hideyoshi's "Chūgoku campaign" (中国攻略) not reached a fever pitch, requiring Oda Nobunaga to head to the frontlines personally to organize a general offensive, Akechi Mitsuhide would have fundamentally found no opportunity to rebel. Had it not been for the mass conscription of garrison troops, Chen Sheng and Wu Guang would never have launched the Daze Village Uprising (大泽乡首义).

Another highly fascinating reason is that, due to the sweltering heat of summer and the bitter cold of winter, rulers of states with fixed capitals might travel to summer palaces (避暑行宫) to escape the heat, and to winter retreats to escape the cold. For states without fixed capitals, the monarch's mobile court (行在) was also highly likely to relocate during these periods.

This situation objectively cultivated the perfect conditions for political conspiracies—a dynamic exceptionally prominent in the histories of both China and Russia.

In our country, the most famous example is undoubtedly the Calamity of Witchcraft (巫蛊之祸). It was precisely because Emperor Wu of Han and his core officials were escaping the summer heat at the Ganquan Palace (甘泉宫) that both the Crown Prince's faction and the anti-Crown Prince faction birthed the idea of annihilating each other within the timeframe of a round trip, harboring the ambition of forcing the emperor to accept a *fait accompli* (既成现实). Conversely, had the emperor remained stationary in the capital, neither faction would have dared to act.

If the travel distance was relatively long, what could possibly be better than eliminating political enemies directly en route?

Because the Yuan Dynasty possessed a "two-capital royal inspection" system (两都巡幸), assassinating the emperor became exceedingly "convenient." Emperor Yingzong was assassinated on the road, and Emperor Mingzong was poisoned in the Central Capital. Both perished in late summer or early autumn, just as they were approaching their return to Beijing.

A chronologically closer example is the 1964 Soviet coup that ousted Nikita Khrushchev. However, this belongs to the category of rapidly seizing power while the adversary is far from the political center; the opposition only struck in October when Khrushchev went vacationing at the Black Sea.

However, this small peak of political turmoil in the summer simply pales in comparison to the grand climax in the winter!

Agricultural activities in the summer might not be as overwhelmingly busy as the spring sowing or the autumn harvest, but tending to the fields still requires active labor. In contrast, the winter in temperate zones is a time of genuine idleness.

Unsuitable for external military campaigns, the ruling class paradoxically finds itself with ample time to scheme and plot "**decapitation-style**" coups (斩首式的政变) right within the political center.

Furthermore, extreme material scarcity and harsh environmental conditions render winter the season when social contradictions are most acutely and explosively intensified throughout the year.

As the new year begins, frequent festivals and religious activities further elevate the success rate of conspiracies.

When one observes the history of the North Temperate Zone, it is remarkably easy to notice that from the moment the weather turns distinctly cold in November, straight through to the following February, the world enters a high-tide period of political turbulence lasting nearly four months.

Below is a list of widely known or monumentally impactful political upheavals that transpired during this specific timeframe:

- **March on Rome (向罗马进军)**, Oct 28, 1922, Kingdom of Italy.
- **October Revolution (十月革命)**, Nov 7, 1917, Russian Provisional Government.
- **Beer Hall Putsch (啤酒馆暴动)**, Nov 8, 1923, Weimar Republic.
- **Coup of 18 Brumaire (雾月政变)**, Nov 9, 1799, French First Republic.
- **Kristallnacht (水晶之夜)**, Nov 9, 1938, Nazi Germany.
- **First Canut Revolt (第一次里昂工人起义)**, Nov 21, 1831, July Monarchy, France.
- **Grand Remonstrance (《大抗议书》)**, Nov 22, 1641, House of Stuart, England.
- **Sweet Dew Incident (甘露之变)**, Nov 835, Tang Dynasty.
- **Kaohsiung Incident / Formosa Incident (美丽岛事件)**, Dec 10, 1979, Taiwan, ROC.
- **Xi'an Incident (西安事变)**, Dec 12, 1936, Republic of China.
- **Coup d'état of December Twelfth (肃军政变)**, Dec 12, 1979, Republic of Korea.
- **Boston Tea Party (波士顿倾茶事件)**, Dec 16, 1773, Thirteen Colonies.
- **Decembrist Revolt (十二月党人起义)**, Dec 26, 1825, Russian Empire.
- **Incident of Seizing the Gate / Duomen Coup (夺门之变)**, 16th day of the 1st lunar month, 1457, Ming Dynasty.
- **Mutiny at Chenqiao (陈桥兵变)**, Feb 960, Later Zhou.
- **Incident at Gaoping Tombs (高平陵之变)**, Feb 249, Cao Wei.
- **Assassination of Minamoto no Sanetomo (刺杀源实朝)**, Feb 13, 1219, Kamakura Shogunate.
- **February 26 Incident (二二六兵变)**, Feb 26, 1936, Empire of Japan.
- **(Disputed) Shadows of Candles and Sounds of Axes (斧声烛影)**, Winter 976, Northern Song.
- **Spartacus Revolt / Third Servile War (斯巴达克斯起义)**, Winter 74-73 BC, Roman Republic.

- **Persian Constitutional Revolution** (波斯资产阶级革命), Winter 1905-1906, Qajar Dynasty.
- **Shimotsuki Incident** (霜月骚动), Winter 1285, Kamakura Shogunate.
- **German Peasants' War** (德国农民战争), Winter 1524-1525, Holy Roman Empire.
- **Shays' Rebellion** (谢司起义), Winter 1786-1787, United States of America.
- **Iranian Islamic Revolution** (伊朗伊斯兰革命), Winter 1978-1979, Pahlavi Dynasty.
- **Shimabara Rebellion** (岛原之乱), Winter 1637-1638, Edo Shogunate.
- **Glorious Revolution** (光荣革命), Winter 1688-1689, Restored House of Stuart, England.
- **German Revolution** (德国革命), Winter 1918-1919, German Empire.
- **1905 Russian Revolution** (1905 年革命), Winter 1904-1905, Russian Empire.
- **Heiji Rebellion** (平治之乱), Winter 1159-1160, Heian Period, Japan.
- **Secession of the Southern States** (南部各州独立), Winter 1860-1861, United States of America.

From the aforementioned examples, it is not difficult to see that the sheer hardship of people's lives during winter massively catalyzed the dissemination of revolutionary ideologies. **Rulers thus found themselves caught in a deadly pincer movement: internal palace coups from within, and popular revolutions from without.**

But the issue obviously does not end there. At the turn of the year, the boiling point of societal discontent coupled with the relative relaxation of the state's violence apparatus provided excellent opportunities for local opportunists. In our country, many of the most infamous rebellions broke out in winter, including the Rebellion of the Seven States (吴楚七国之乱), the An Lushan Rebellion (安史之乱), and the Revolt of the Three Feudatories (三藩之乱).

As the agricultural era faded into the distance, the severe material scarcity of winter was indeed greatly alleviated—but this is merely surface-level. From another perspective, material scarcity in winter remains a reality compared to other seasons; I believe anyone who experienced China's three-year pandemic lockdown measures could never possibly forget this fact.

More importantly, with the rapid expansion of urbanization, the quantity and quality of public services demanded by winter residents have skyrocketed. For example, the stress on heating grids and power grids surges exponentially. **This renders strikes and protests by revolutionaries devastatingly effective; there is absolutely nothing more powerful than applying pressure on a government at this precise timing.**

For the rulers, an even more dire situation is that modern civilization allows ordinary people in most parts of the world to enjoy more holidays.

For instance, in the previous examples, we cited two classic coups that occurred during the first lunar month precisely because the ruler had to attend mandatory political ceremonies. The first was the **Incident at Gaoping Tombs** (高平陵之变) during the Cao Wei period. This falls into the category of rapidly seizing power while the rival faction is far from the political center. When Cao Shuang (曹爽) accompanied Emperor Cao Fang to sweep the tombs at Gaoping, Sima Yi (司马懿)

seized the flawless opportunity to strike and completely took control of Luoyang. The second event was the assassination of the *Sei-i Taishōgun* Minamoto no Sanetomo by his nephew, Minamoto no Kugyō, while visiting the Tsurugaoka Hachimangū shrine. This belongs to the category of a direct decapitation strike executed when the opponent's defenses were thinned due to attending ceremonial activities.

Unless a ruler was an absolute shut-in who "never stepped past the front gate nor the second gate" (大门不出, 二门不迈) like the Wanli Emperor of the Ming Dynasty, it was practically impossible for rulers of temperate nations not to attend necessary ceremonial activities during this time, as the start of the year was universally set in winter. This inevitably manufactured perfect opportunities for coups!

However, in ancient times, this at least had nothing to do with the commoners. In an agricultural society, could peasants visiting relatives for the New Year genuinely travel hundreds of kilometers away?

However, the rapid development of society since the Industrial Revolution implies that major holidays are now accompanied by two exceedingly crucial phenomena: **intensified population mobility and heightened mass gatherings.**

Once these two factors combine with the lightning speed of modern information transmission, it inevitably causes negative public opinion to ferment and spread within an incredibly short timeframe. The people's grievances and their hostility toward the current regime escalate rapidly.

This fact has been repeatedly verified across the globe over the past century or more. New Year celebrations, religious festivals, and memorial services for specific figures frequently morph into the detonators of turbulence and revolution.

In the latter half of the last century, the world-shocking Iranian Islamic Revolution served as a classic example. At the end of 1978, during "Muharram" (the first month of the Islamic calendar), the demands to depose the Shah and welcome Khomeini back surged precipitously. Consequently, on the two days of December 10 and 11, it was reported that over 10% of Iran's entire national population participated in the demonstrations, setting the highest historical record to date for the percentage of a national population participating in a political protest!

Interestingly, because there is an annual time differential between the Islamic lunar calendar and the Gregorian calendar, a roughly **33-year "interference cycle"** (干涉周期) forms along the timeline. After every cycle, the major festivals and ceremonies within Islamic law will reappear in roughly the same seasonal position in the Gregorian year.

It is not difficult to notice that around 1979, a series of upheavals occurred in the Islamic world, marking the genesis of the modern Islamic revival movement and regional geopolitical conflicts. **And the subsequent Arab Spring movement erupted precisely about one cycle later!**

It is easy to observe that after entering the industrial society, the danger of summer has rapidly dissipated. For rulers, threats have become increasingly concentrated in the winter. The surging Communist and Fascist movements in the first half of the 20th century already illustrated this point.

This pattern manifested even more glaringly during the dramatic upheavals in the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe (苏东巨变), as well as the widespread regime changes across the Eurasian continent.

On the eve of the collapse of the Soviet bloc, the political activities of the opposition frequently peaked in the spring and summer, and ultimately secured victory in the winter.

(Of course, this does not mean revolutionaries ceased making powerful responses in the summer; the famous Baltic Way movement occurred in the summer of 1989).

- **Kosovo Miners' Strike** (科索沃大罢工), Feb 1989, Socialist Federal Republic of Yugoslavia.
- **Resignation of Erich Honecker** (东德昂纳克下台), Oct 18, 1989, East Germany (GDR).
- **Velvet Revolution** (天鹅绒革命), Nov 1989, Czechoslovakia.
- **Seven-Day Revolution / Romanian Revolution** (七日革命), Dec 1989, Socialist Republic of Romania.
- **Democratization of Poland** (波兰民主化), Winter 1989-1990, Polish People's Republic.
- **Democratization of Hungary** (匈牙利民主化), Winter 1989-1990, Hungarian People's Republic.
- **Democratization of Bulgaria** (保加利亚民主化), Winter 1989-1990, People's Republic of Bulgaria.
- **Democratization of Albania** (阿尔巴尼亚民主化), Winter 1989-1990, People's Socialist Republic of Albania.
- **Dissolution of the League of Communists of Yugoslavia** (南共亡党), Feb 1990, SFR Yugoslavia.
- **Georgian Declaration of Independence / Moves toward Independence** (格鲁吉亚独立宣言), Nov 4, 1990, USSR.
- **Dissolution of the Soviet Union** (苏联解体), Dec 25, 1991, USSR.
- **Rose Revolution** (玫瑰花革命), Nov 22, 2003, Georgia.
- **Orange Revolution** (橙色革命), Nov-Dec 2004, Ukraine.
- **Cedar Revolution** (雪松革命), Feb 14, 2005, Lebanon.
- **Jasmine Revolution** (茉莉花革命), 2010-2011, Tunisia.

The politics of temperate nations progress along this curve year after year: entering a perilous period starting in November, which lasts straight through to the following February.

Once spring arrives, even the most intense social contradictions will experience varying degrees of mitigation. After all, spring signifies a reduction in survival pressure. Humans are simply wired this way: even when perfectly aware that a long-term downward spiral is inevitable, any minor short-term improvement will instill the mentality of "**enduring just one more day**" (忍一天是一天).

In ancient times, there would be a secondary danger period from late May to late August, which would then ease again in the autumn. However, this has largely vanished in industrial societies.

By pointing out the seasonal cyclicity of political crises, we are, of course, absolutely not claiming that transformations *must* occur in winter or summer.

For instance, we can imagine extreme scenarios: if a rare, catastrophic drought strikes in the spring—especially if it persists after several consecutive years of prior droughts—to the point where peasants can definitively judge that survival this year is utterly impossible, they will simply rise up in rebellion right in the spring! The peasant wars of the late Ming Dynasty started exactly like this.

Alternatively, if the social pressure of an entire region has completely overloaded, and revolutionary storms are simultaneously brewing in many countries, then for the rulers, they cannot expect any amelioration of the situation even when spring arrives. The revolutions of 1848 that swept across Europe were exactly like this: they initially erupted in winter, but actually expanded massively in the spring!

In the final analysis, **seasonal changes can only serve as a catalytic force (推动作用); the internal socio-economic and political factors of a society are what are truly decisive!**

We can use a simple mathematical model to explain why political upheavals so frequently occur in winter.

Imagine a coordinate axis: the horizontal axis represents time, and the dependent variable (因变量) on the vertical axis represents the total pressure borne by the entire society.

Consider a society that has evolved into its late stage. Although the dependent variable fluctuates over time, its overall trajectory is inevitably on an upward trend.

Let us introduce a supplementary assumption: the current regime makes absolutely no policy changes, and the operational mode of society remains stagnant. This means the growth rate of the social pressure variable is a constant—or approximately, the social pressure curve can be fitted with a linear function (straight line) possessing a positive slope.

Now, let us visualize how social pressure fluctuates around this growing linear trend over time: as winter approaches, there is a distinct surge; this is followed by a minor downward trend in the ensuing spring, a relatively smaller uptick in summer, and a moderating trend in autumn.

Visually, this is the summation of a **sine function (正弦函数)** and a **linear function (一次函数)**, with the caveat that this "sine wave" consists of alternating major and minor waves.

How exactly does this late-stage society evolve? Obviously, it depends on the amplitude of the waves and the original slope of the linear trend. But regardless, if we assume this society possesses a **"collapse threshold" (崩溃阈值)**—meaning regime change occurs the moment the pressure curve hits a specific value for the first time—then the inherent seasonal spike in winter, superimposed onto the natural chronological accumulation of social pressure, will result in a massive, distinct leap in social pressure during the entire winter season!

From a mathematical perspective, it is entirely rational that the summer and winter seasons contribute to the vast majority of political upheavals. And as the amplitude of the summer pressure increase dramatically diminishes (*in the industrial age*), the timing of political upheavals becomes increasingly concentrated in the winter.

I believe this knowledge, which is practically useless to ordinary people, is actually crystal clear to the governments of major global powers. Because for a state to maintain its rule, it must precisely know when to tighten policies and when to relax them. And if the goal is to execute political subversion against another state, the timing of exerting force is paramount.

The vast majority of opposition organizational activities should be concentrated in winter, specifically clustered around the onset of winter and the New Year. As for April, May, September, and October, maintaining a minimal presence is sufficient.

Another fascinating point is that, while non-democratic regimes do not need to worry about elections, democratic states must constantly consider election timing.

In the wave of democratization following the total collapse of the Soviet Union and its bloc, many newly formed states scheduled their elections at the end of the year, in October or November. While I cannot know exactly why they made this choice, it is highly probable that the United States created a "**demonstration effect**" (示范效应). Since the US holds its presidential elections at the end of the year, ensuring the new leader and government formally take office at the beginning of the following year, others simply copied it.

However, for nations in the Northern Hemisphere, elections and the onset of winter happen practically back-to-back! This astronomically spikes the probability of a rapidly deteriorating situation. China's so-called "**Color Revolutions**" (颜色革命) frequently transpire in the winter immediately following an election, generally triggered by opposition protests refusing to recognize the election results.

For a country like Ukraine, where the domestic situation was inherently unstable to begin with, this specific election timing naturally serves as a potent catalyst for political upheaval.

What many small nations completely fail to grasp is that just because the United States does something, it obviously does not mean they need to copy it! The international status and social welfare net of the US can indeed absorb the shock of an election around the onset of winter without triggering massive turmoil. *(Not to mention, even the US experienced the incident where Trump supporters stormed the Capitol the year before last—which happened precisely on January 6th!)*

In fact, I have noticed that not all world powers arrange their election schedules according to the US model. For instance, the French seem more inclined to hold their presidential elections mid-year. **Changing the government at the exact moment when the populace is at their most docile is clearly a stroke of political brilliance.**

Finally, it must be emphasized that the observations above are based on temperate and subtropical zones. While temperate and subtropical zones generally represent the mainstream of human historical development, tropical regions also harbor massive populations and richly diverse civilizations. The history of the tropics is naturally an inseparable part of human history. *(In fact, I myself was born in Zhanjiang, Guangdong Province—one of the extremely rare tropical regions distributed within China).*

The tropics lack the distinction of spring, summer, autumn, and winter; they only have the distinction between the dry season and the wet season. Therefore, the impact of cyclical seasonal shifts on political activities in the tropics obviously cannot be identical to that in temperate zones.

For example, during the monsoon (wet) season in India and Southeast Asia, not only is transportation severely obstructed, but the very boundaries of political power actually contract! This is precisely the reason why these regions easily birthed the so-called "**Mandala system**" (曼陀罗体制). Consequently, large-scale military operations would be conducted in the "winter"—after all, winter in these regions has virtually no connection to the concept of "cold."

The examples of the tropics constantly remind me of how incredibly profound and diverse human civilization is. When we observe history, it is absolutely impossible to succeed without adopting a comprehensive and holistic perspective.

十，季节与政治动荡

这和第五章一样属于非常短的一章，属于是个人日常的随笔，它与整个记录的主题没有任何关系，读者可以直接跳过。22 年末冬天将近的时候，中国许多城市都出现了对于疫情管控措施的反抗行动，这是“抗疫大业”在 22 年年底结束的直接原因之一。我有感于此，意识到人类古往今来的政治变动与季节有着密切的关系，于是在 23 年八月底写了这篇随笔，虽然业余时间不足以支撑我对于人类历史上所有动摇或者颠覆政权的叛乱、起义、政变等重大政治事件进行统计学分析，而只能列举一些我所比较了解的历史事件，我相信如果有人能够对此问题进行科学的数据分析那么这个结论只能得到更加充分地证明。特别是自近现代以来对人类历史进程产生重大影响的政治变动已经高度集中在冬季的三四个月中，这是不言自明的。对于那些呼唤一场彻底社会变革的地区，“冬将军”是时代的弄潮儿们最为可靠和强力的盟友。

之前看法国大革命时期历史的时候，对“热月政变”这一历史事件的名字印象极为深刻，这场政变发生在共和历的热月，有趣的是，从历史上看炎热的夏季的确是政治动荡的一个高发期。这无非是因为人类迄今为止的大部分历史都是农业文明史（信史时代以来，温带地区又是人类文明的主流），春天以播种为主，秋天以收获为主，冬天寒冷行止困难，对于温带政权而言，有什么比夏天发动战争更合适呢？而战争毫无疑问是对社会财富破坏最大的一种人类活动，这就为各种政变叛乱和起义提供了条件。人们可以轻而易举地列举一些著名或者有影响力的发生在夏季的这些类别的重大政治事件。

扎克雷起义，1358.5-6，法国瓦卢瓦王朝。

瓦特·泰勒起义，1381.6，英国金雀花王朝。

凯德起义，1450.6-7，英国兰开斯特王朝。

西里西亚纺织工人起义，1844.6.4，普鲁士王国。

《大宪章》，1215.6.15，英国金雀花王朝

本能寺之变，1582.6.21，日本安土桃山时期。

嘉吉之乱，1441.6.24，室町幕府。

叶卡捷琳娜二世夺权，1762.6.28，俄罗斯帝国。

萨拉热窝事件，1914.6.28，奥匈帝国。

波兹南事件，1956.6.28，波兰人民共和国。

长刀之夜，1934.6.30，纳粹德国。

乙巳之变，645.6，日本飞鸟时期。

玄武门之变，626.7.2，唐朝。

大革命，1789.7.14，法国波旁王朝。

弗朗哥起事，1936.7.17，西班牙共和国。

刺杀希特勒，1944.7.20，纳粹德国。

唐隆政变，710.7.21，唐朝。

埃及七月革命，1952.7.23，埃及王国。

热月政变，1794.7.27，法兰西第一共和国。

七月革命，1830 年七月底，法国复辟波旁王朝。

第一次掷出窗外事件，1419.7.30，波西米亚王国。

金田起义，1850.7，清朝。

南昌起义，1927.8.1，中华民国。

靖难之役，1399.8.6，明朝。

八一九事件，1991.8.19，苏联。

英国内战爆发，1642.8.22，英国斯图亚特王朝。

圣巴托洛缪大屠杀，1572.8.24，法国瓦卢瓦王朝。

太清之难，548.8，南梁。

彼得一世夺权，1689.8，俄罗斯沙皇国。

米骚动，1918.8，日本帝国。

观应扰乱，1349年夏，室町幕府。

1978年示威，1978年夏，巴列维王朝。

白马驿之祸，905年夏，唐朝。

王建举事，918年夏，朝鲜后三国时期。

梳毛工起义，1378年夏，佛罗伦萨共和国。

可以很明显看出，上述事件的发生有许多都与战争有关，假如不是羽柴秀吉的“中国攻略”进入白热化，需要信长亲往前线组织总攻，那明智光秀根本找不到机会反叛。如果不是征调戍卒，陈胜吴广也不会在大泽乡首义。另一个十分有趣的原因是，由于夏热冬寒，有固定首都的国家统治者在夏天可能去行宫避暑，冬天去行宫避寒。没有固定首都的国家，君主行在也很有可能在此时移动。这种情况客观上为政治密谋提供了条件，以中国和俄国两国的历史尤为突出。在我国最著名的例子莫过于巫蛊之祸，正是汉武帝和核心官员在甘泉宫避暑，太子一派和反太子一派才会萌生出在一个往返的时间内消灭对方的想法和迫使皇帝承认既成现实的野心。反之如果皇帝留在首都不动，太子和反太子两派都不敢有所行动。如果出行距离较远的话，有什么比直接在路上消灭政敌更好的呢？元朝因为存在两都巡幸制度，刺王杀驾就变得十分“方便”，英宗在路上被杀，明宗在中都被下毒，他们都是在夏末秋初接近返回北京时去世的。在时间上更近的例子有苏联在1964年驱逐赫鲁晓夫的政变，不过这个属于在敌方远离政治中心时迅速夺权，十月份赫鲁晓夫前往黑海度假的时候反对派才动手。

然而夏天这个政治动荡的小高峰在面对冬季这个大高潮的时候就是小巫见大巫了。夏季的农业活动或许没有春秋忙碌，但是打理农田一样是需要经历的，可是温带的冬天却是真正意义上闲得无事。不方便进行军事行动，统治阶级反倒有了充足的时间考虑，在政治中心进行斩首式的政变。物资匮乏，环境恶劣，使得冬季成为一年四季中社会矛盾最为尖锐激化的时段。一年复始，频繁的节日和宗教活动更加提高了阴谋的成功率。当人们观察北温带的历史，就很容易注意到从11月天气明显转凉开始，一直到次年二月份会进入为期近四个月的政治动荡高潮期。下面列举历史上在这一时段发生的人们耳熟能详或者影响重大的政治变动。

向罗马进军，1922.10.28，意大利王国。

十月革命，1917.11.7，俄国资产阶级政府。

啤酒馆暴动，1923.11.8，魏玛共和国。

雾月政变，1799.11.9，法兰西第一共和国。

水晶之夜，1938.11.9，纳粹德国。

第一次里昂工人起义，1831.11.21，法国七月王朝。

《大抗议书》，1641.11.22，英国斯图亚特王朝。

甘露之变，835.11，唐朝。

美丽岛事件，1979.12.10，中国台湾。

西安事变，1936.12.12，中华民国。

肃军政变，1979.12.12，大韩民国。

波士顿倾茶事件，1773.12.16，英属北美十三州。

十二月党人起义，1825.12.26，俄罗斯帝国。

夺门之变，1457年正月十六，明朝。

陈桥兵变，960.2，后周。

高平陵之变，249.2，曹魏。

刺杀源实朝，1219.2.13，镰仓幕府。

二二六兵变，1936.2.26，日本帝国。

（存疑）斧声烛影，976年冬，北宋。

斯巴达克斯起义，前74—73年冬，罗马共和国。

波斯资产阶级革命，1905—1906年冬，卡扎尔王朝。

霜月骚动，1285年冬，镰仓幕府。

德国农民战争，1524—1525年冬，神圣罗马帝国。

谢司起义，1786—1787 年冬，美利坚合众国。

伊朗伊斯兰革命，1978—1979 年冬，巴列维王朝。

岛原之乱，1637—1638 年冬，江户幕府。

光荣革命，1688—1689 年冬，英国复辟斯图亚特王朝。

德国革命，1918—1919 年冬，德意志第二帝国。

1905 年革命，1904—1905 年冬，俄罗斯帝国。

平治之乱，1159—1160 年冬，日本平安时期。

南部各州独立，1860—1861 年冬，美利坚合众国。

从上述例子不难看出，冬天人民生活的艰难大大促进了求变思想的传播，统治者受到了内部宫廷政变和外部人民革命的双重夹击。但问题显然还不止于此，岁末年初之时，不满情绪的升温以及国家暴力机关的松懈为地方的野心家提供了良好的机遇，在我国，许多极为有名的叛乱都是在冬季发生的，包括吴楚七国之乱，安史之乱和三藩之乱。随着农业时代的远去，冬天物资匮乏的情况的确得到了很大缓解，但这只是表面上的事。另一方面，冬季相比于其他季节仍然存在物资匮乏的情况，我认为经历过中国三年疫情管控措施的人不可能忘记这一点。更重要的是，随着城市化的迅猛发展冬季居民对于公共服务质和量的需求都变得很高，例如供暖和供电的压力会激增，这就使得革命者的罢工和抗议变得更加有效，没有什么比在这个时间点对政府施压更有力的了。

对统治者而言另一个更糟糕的情况是，现代文明使得全世界绝大多数地区的普通人也可以更多享受节假日。比方说在之前的例子里面，我们举了两个在正月因为统治者出席必要的政治活动而导致的典型政变，第一个是曹魏时期的高平陵之变，这属于在敌对方远离政治中心的时候快速夺权，当曹爽陪同皇帝曹芳前往高平陵扫墓的时候，司马懿抓住机会出手控制的洛阳。另一个事件是征夷大将军源实朝在鹤冈八幡宫参拜时被侄子源公晓刺杀，这属于在敌对方因出席活动而防卫薄弱时而直接进行斩首的行动。除非像万历皇帝这样大门不出，二门不迈的统治者，因为温带国家普遍把岁首设在冬天，统治者很难不在此时出席一些必要的活动，这就造成了政变的机遇。不过在古代，这跟普通人至少是没什么关系的，在农业社会，农民过年串门难道还能跑到上百公里之外吗？

然而，工业革命以来社会的迅猛发展意味着重大节日会伴随着两个极为重要的现象，那就是人口流动性加剧和聚集性上升，这一旦和现代信息传播的迅速相结合，就不可避免地导致负面舆论在很短的时间内传播发酵，人民的不满情绪以及对现政权的敌对心理迅速升温。这一事实在过去一个多世纪中在全球各个地方被反复检验，新年、宗教节日和特殊人物的追悼会往往变成动荡和革命的导火索。上个世纪后半叶，举世皆惊的伊朗伊斯兰革命就非常典型，在 1978 年底伊斯兰教历的一月份“穆哈兰姆月”，要求废除国王赢回霍梅尼的声音陡然高涨，以至于在 12 月 10 日和 11 日两天，据说超过伊朗全国人口 10% 的民众参与了示威，创造了迄今为止政治抗议活动参与人数占全国人口比例最高的历史记录。有趣的是，由于伊斯兰历法和公历每一年都具有时差，这样在时间轴上就会形成一个约 33 年的“干涉周期”。每经过一个周期，伊斯兰立法中的重要节日和庆典都会出现在公历纪元一年中相近的位置上。人们不难发现，1979 年前后伊斯兰世界出现了一系列骚动，这成为了现代伊斯兰复兴运动和地缘冲突的起点，而后来的阿拉伯之春运动与其恰好间隔约一个周期。

人们不难发现，进入工业社会之后，夏季的危险性正在迅速消失，对统治者来说威胁越来越集中于冬季，20 世纪上半叶风起云涌的共产主义运动和法西斯运动就已经说明了这一点。而它甚至在苏东巨变以及欧亚大陆普遍的政权更迭中显现得更为明显，在苏东巨变前夜，反对派的政治活动往往在春夏两季达到高峰，并最终在冬天取得胜利。当然革命者也不是不再在夏天进行有力的回应，著名的波罗的海之路运动就发生在 1989 年夏天。

科索沃大罢工，1989.2，南斯拉夫社会主义联邦共和国。

东德昂纳克下台，1989.10.18，民主德国。

天鹅绒革命，1989.11，捷克斯洛伐克。

七日革命，1989. 12，罗马尼亚社会主义共和国。

波兰民主化，1989-1990 冬，波兰人民共和国。

匈牙利民主化，1989-1990 冬，匈牙利人民共和国。

保加利亚民主化，1989-1990 冬，保加利亚人民共和国。

阿尔巴尼亚民主化，1989-1990 冬，阿尔巴尼亚社会主义人民共和国。

南共亡党，1990.2，南斯拉夫社会主义联邦共和国。

格鲁吉亚独立宣言，1990.11.4，苏维埃社会主义共和国联盟。

苏联解体，1991.12.25，苏维埃社会主义共和国联盟。

玫瑰花革命，2003.11.22，格鲁吉亚。

橙色革命，2004.11-12，乌克兰。

雪松革命，2005.2.14，黎巴嫩。

茉莉花革命，2010-2011，突尼斯。

温带国家的政治沿着这个曲线年复一年地行进，从11月开始进入一个危险的时期，一直持续到次年二月。一旦开春，再激烈的社会矛盾都会存在不同程度的缓和，毕竟春天意味着生存压力的减小。人类就是这样的，哪怕明知长远来看江河日下是不可避免的事情，但是任何短期内的小幅改善都会让人有忍一天是一天的想法。如果是在古代的话，从五月底到八月底结束会有一个次危险的阶段，在秋天又有所缓和，不过这在工业社会已经基本消失了。

我们指出政治危机存在季节性周期当然不是说变革必然在冬天或者夏天发生，例如我们可以想象极端的情况，如果春天遭遇到罕见的大旱特别是已经在几年干旱之后仍然持续干旱，以至于农民已经可以判断今年根本无法生存，那么他们干脆春天就会起义，明末农民战争就是这么开始的。或者说整个地区的社会压力已经完全过载，革命风暴同时在很多国家酝酿，那么对统治者来说即使到春天也不能指望形势有任何好转。在1848年席卷欧洲的革命就是这样，它最初在冬天爆发，反而在春天扩大了。归根到底，季节变化也只能是起到推动作用，而社会内在的因素才是决定性的。

我们用一个简单的数学模型就可以解释为什么政治变动往往发生在冬天。现在想象一个坐标轴，横坐标是时间，纵坐标所示的因变量是整个社会所承受的压力。考虑一个演化到晚期的社会，那么因变量虽然随着时间有所波动，但是在整体上必然处于上升状态。我们再进行一个补充的假设，也就是现政权不作出任何政策改变，社会的运行模式保持稳定，这意味着社会压力的变量处于定值，也就是近似的假定社会压力曲线被一条斜率为正的直线拟合。那么我们想向社会压力随着时间围绕这个增长的直线的波动情况，当它接近冬天的时候会出现一个明显的增长，然后在接下来的春天呈现一个小的下降趋势，在夏天呈现一个不那么大的增幅，在秋天又呈现出缓和的趋势。形象地来看，就是一个正弦函数和一个一次函数的加和，只不过这个“正弦函数”是一种大波和另一种要小一些波交替，这个晚期社会具体怎么演变？显然跟波的大小以及直线原本的斜率有关。但是无论如何，如果我们假定这个社会存在一个崩溃阈值，也就是当压力曲线第一次增长到某个值的话就会发生政权更迭，那么冬季固有的社会压力增加与社会压力随着时间自然的增加值相叠加，在整个冬天社会压力就会出现一次明显的跃升。从数学上看，夏冬两季贡献了绝大多数的政治变动是有合理性的，而随着夏天社会压力增加的幅度大为减小，政治变动发生的时间就越来越集中在冬季了。

我认为这个对于普通人没什么用的知识反倒是各个主要国家的政府都十分清楚的。因为一个国家要维护自己的统治，就必须知道政策什么时候收紧，什么时候放松。而如果要对另一个国家进行政治颠覆，那么什么时候发力就很重要了。大部分反对活动的组织都应该集中到冬季，而冬天的活动又应该集中在刚入冬和过年前后。至于四月，五月，九月，十月维持最低限度的存在就行了。另一个有意思的事是，虽然非民主政权不需要考虑选举，但是民主国家总是要考虑大选的时间。在苏联及其阵营土崩瓦解之后的民主浪潮中新形成的很多国家把选举的时间定在年末的十月十一月。虽然我不可能知道他们为什么这么选择，但是从推测上很可能是因为美国形成了一种示范效应，因为美国就是在年底进行总统选举，从而确保新的领导人和政府能够在第二年的开始正式执政。可是对于北半球的国家来说，选举和入冬是前后脚的事情，这就让局势恶化的可能直线上升，中国所谓的“颜色革命”就往往发生在选举完的冬天，一般是以反对派不承认选举结果的抗议示威开始的。像乌克兰这种国内局势本来就不稳定的国家，这个选举时间自然就成为政治变动的强力催化剂。很多小国家可能没有明白的是，美国怎么做显然不等于自己也需要怎么做，美国的国际地位和社会保障确实可以让选举在入冬前后进行而不至于出现大的变乱。更不要说即使是美国在前年也发生过特朗普的支持者冲击国会的事件，那就是1月6号的事。事实上我注意到即使是其他世界强国也不是都按照美国去安排选举时间，例如法国人似乎就更倾向在年中进行总统换届选举，这种在人民最温顺的时候进行更换政府的做法显然是高明的。

最后需要强调的是，以上观察是以温带和亚热带地区作为观察对象做出的，虽然温带和亚热带地区从总体上看代表人类历史发展的主流，但是热带地区同样存在庞大的人口以及丰富多样的文明，热带的

历史自然是人类历史无法分割的一部分，事实上我本人就出生在中国分布极少的热带地区，即广东省湛江市。热带缺少春夏秋冬四季的区分，而只有旱季和雨季的分别，因此热带地区季节的周期性变动对政治活动的影响显然不可能与温带相同。例如在印度和东南亚的雨季不要说交通会受到极大阻碍，政治权力的边界甚至都会出现收缩，这也是这些地区容易产生所谓“曼陀罗体制”的原因，而大规模的军事行动就会在冬季进行了，毕竟这里的冬天跟寒冷几乎挂不上钩。热带的例子时刻提醒着我人类的文明是如此的丰富，当我们观察历史的时候不采用更全面的视角是不行的。